## SHIFTING SOUNDS

» By mid 1980s, the music market opens up as the duopoly of HMV and Polydor (Music India) is challenged by the arrival of T-Series, Magnasound, Venus and CBS Records

» By the '90s, audio cassettes were a sonic boom; only the US sold more than India

» In 1991, MTV comes to India. Channel V is born in 1994. MTV India kicks off in 1996. Indipop stars Alisha Chinai, Baba Sehgal, Lucky Ali, Daler Mehndi rule

» Bollywood joins the parade: A.R. Rahman, Sonu Nigam, Asha Bhosle release their own non-film albums

» Rising musicians like Ram Sampath, Salim-Sulaiman, Raju Singh get coopted by B'wood. Film music gets a new sound

» Music videos are all the rage, with their slick ad film aesthetic. The makers (Rakeysh Omprakash Mehra, Ken Ghosh...) soon turn to film direction

» Punjabi bhangra-pop takes over the world. From Daler Mehndi to Diljit Dosanjh and A.P. Dhillon, it rules streaming platforms



**"If they can freak out over us, I can think of worse ways they can spend their energy. We give them healthy, peppy sounds. We give them something a whole lot better than drugs or free sex"**

**— SHARON PRABHAKAR**



**BHANGRA PIONEER**
Malkit Singh

Alisha Chinai, Preeti Sagar, Suneeta Rao. By the '90s, this motley crew had been collectively christened Indipop.

And was it popping! Apache Indian and Baba Sehgal brought in rap—Vanilla Ice's *Ice Ice Baby* became 'Thanda Thanda Paani'. Chinai and Biddu topped the charts with *Made in India*. Lucky Ali got everyone crooning to 'O Sanam'. Accelerating their popularity was satellite television—India now had MTV and Channel V. They shared space with a global smorgasbord. The number of Indipop videos made shot up from 36 in 1996 to over 600 in 1999; the genre covered some 6 per cent of the market. Its internal span, too, was widened and enriched as classically trained singers like Shankar Mahadevan, Shubha Mudgal and Hariharan (teaming with Leslie Lewis for *Colonial Cousins*) joined the scene.

The linguistic canvas expanded beyond Hinglish: Punjabi folk-pop broke down the doors, first with Malkit Singh, and then with a bundle of energy called Daler Mehndi. If a poverty of ideas lingered, remixed Hindi film classics filled the gap.

But filmdom soon began predating upon the genre to bring the party home. Even as film folks like Asha Bhosle, Anu Malik and even Amitabh Bachchan dabbled on that side—as did A.R. Rahman, one born on the cusp of sensibilities—cinema lured pop stars like Shaan, Lucky Ali, Mohit Chauhan of Silk Route, Adnan Sami, Chinai and Shweta Shetty for playback singing and Indipop composers like Ram Sampath, Ranjit Barot and Salim-Sulaiman to pep up soundtracks. By the mid-2000s, says Churamani, there was little novelty left and music channels struggled for ad revenues, turning to reality shows instead. But the music genie itself was out of the bottle. The non-film ecosystem, ever diversifying, pops and fizzes in the age of YouTube and Spotify. ■